



Reading/Writing 2.0

Much learning and recreation today is still in the form of the written word, to be imbibed by reading. We take a peek into the future to see how human kind would eventually consume. Won't we read anymore?



Electronic Paper

Electronic paper is a display technology which gives the appearance of ordinary ink on paper. It's more readable, than LCDs, in sunlight. Also it can display a stable image continuously without consuming electricity thereby drastically reducing the power consumption. It only needs external power to change the image being displayed. The Dutch company iRex has designed the reader iLiad which allows the readers to write on e-paper with a stylus. Ongoing research will soon equip e-paper to have full colour display and capable of displaying videos which is not possible due to current frame refresh rates nearing a second. Mirasol Displays by Qualcomm is huge a step towards this. Read more: <http://bit.ly/DMirasol>



Rolling Paper Like Displays

Sony has demonstrated a flexible colour display which can be wrapped around a pencil. The screen, although crude in quality currently, are able to display colour and video without being affected by the rolling. It uses organic thin film transistors for its circuits which can be fabricated on a flexible substrate thus eliminating the need for rigid chips.

Being a fiction writer is not as easy as one may think, especially in today's day and age. Kamal had been working on a new concept for a science fiction series for quite some time now and was contemplating options. The story's central theme was a new kind of a polygraph (or lie-detector) being invented which interfaced directly with the nervous system and was a hundred percent accurate. The plot mostly dealt with the socio-political storm such an invention would kick up. However, Kamal's concerns weren't so much about the creative direction that the book would take but rather the publishing options.

In the new age, one would expect that the new technologies, wider audiences and unlimited outreach would make writing easier and more enriching. However, as it turned out, it only complicated matters. Kamal had to look into the suitability of the story for the traditional paper medium and also the electronic medium. The advent of 3D augmented reality books had made it quite scary. In order to write a commercially successful book one also needed to incorporate special 3D and AR features to enhance the reading experience. Like special effects in the movies, Kamal have to tweak his story line to incorporate breath-taking animations and complicated 3D illustrations to attract more readers.

As if this alone wasn't enough, the publishing house puts e-book readers in his kitty too. These days, any new book had to be appealing to the new age e-book readers. They were simple electronic paper readers which were quite primitive and did not require any special effort from the author's side but one still needed to write a demo chapter with enhanced media.

Rigid e-paper readers were quite out of fashion now and new age rolling e-paper readers came equipped with 3D and AR capabilities. One would think that handling 3D and AR content in electronic medium would not require any extra effort over the 3D paper medium. But, one couldn't be more wrong to expect that. For a while 3D was an enhancement for story telling, but nowadays mere 3D sells stories.

And finally, the biggest niggle was that, the new age e-reader interfaces and software come in to make one's life difficult. They enabled collaborative book reviews, personal book clubs and what not. Hence, Kamal need to appease this community of new age social readers too.

And so he was left with the most Herculean task of his life – that of appealing to all the myriad mindsets and reading aficionados out there at the same time. Though he envisioned the future, Kamal bet H.G. Wells never had to deal with such complexities! Dealing with the future is quite different from thinking about it. 



3D Augmented Reality Books

South Korea's Gwangju Institute animated two Korean folklore children's books using 3D software. One can see animation associated with certain images of the book with the assistance of 3D glasses. Similarly, Metaio has developed an augmented reality technology which superimposes 3D objects on a book through camera recognition software. The user can download the software and use it on any windows PC equipped with a modern webcam. The image processing software identifies the book using a webcam and no glasses are required.

Future E-reader Interfaces

Future interfaces will enable e-readers to have additional content provided by users. Users will be able to append informational layers, background details etc. and debate on the content developing the augmented text collaboratively. The software will enable networking with like-minded readers. With content being developed specially for the electronic medium, one can expect stories developing based on reader's input. Readers may communicate with the characters using their communication devices, discover hidden chapters and plot twists after solving certain clues hidden within the text and explore non-linear storylines via real time input.